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What does mental rest mean to professional athletes? A study of National Football League players

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ABSTRACT

Objectives: To better understand the concept of mental rest in professional athletes. Mental rest appears to be important for recovery and movement skill learning, yet there is limited understanding of this concept in the professional athlete context.
Design: A qualitative description study design was employed.
Method: Sixteen NFL athletes were interviewed about what mental rest means to them. A codebook thematic analysis was undertaken to examine the analytical generalizability to the professional athlete context of an extant model of mental rest proposed based on a study of college athletes (Eccles & Kazmier, 2019).
Results: The Eccles and Kazmier model offers considerable analytical generalizability to the professional athlete context. Consistent with the model, the process of resting mentally in professional athletes includes (a) sleep and (b) resting while awake, involving multiple resting experiences including a break from thinking about one's sport. Departures from the model were also observed. For example, in the original model, to achieve a break from thinking about one's sport, college athletes spent time on a rest day in public locations (e.g., restaurants) within which there were few cues to think about their sport (e.g., no teammates). In contrast, for recognizable professional athletes studied here, public locations often offered no escape from these cues due to uninvited questions from the public about their sport.
Conclusion: The findings advance understanding of the constituents of mental rest in professional athletes and inform education about how athletes can obtain the mental rest needed to perform effectively and stay healthy.

Mental rest appears to be important to professional athletes. For example, National Football League (NFL) quarterback Jared Goff reports going fishing on rest days so that he can "think about nothing that has to do with football" (Manning et al., 2025). Despite the apparent importance of mental rest for professional athletes, little research attention has been paid to understanding this concept in this population. Therefore, the objective of this study is to better understand mental rest in professional athletes. To this end, we frame our study of professional athletes using a model of mental rest in athletes proposed by Eccles and Kazmier (2019). This model was developed based on a study of college athletes, who are dual-career athletes who balance sport with academics. By contrast, professional athletes face different demands: They are single career athletes who focus solely on their sport, but their sport is also their job, and one that is precarious. Thus, we explore the extent to which the model of mental rest proposed by Eccles and Kazmier offers analytical generalizability (Smith, 2018) to the professional athlete context.

A literature review concerned with rest in sport by Eccles et al. (2022) indicates that rest is considered key to an understanding of two areas of athlete functioning: recovery (Kellmann et al., 2018) and movement skill learning (Shea et al., 2000). Within the literature concerned with recovery, rest is typically considered to involve the cessation or reduction of physical participation in training and competition and as important in contributing to recovery following training and competition (Kellmann et al., 2018). Recovery is considered to be the replenishment of physical and mental resources after they have been depleted by engagement in training and competition (Balk et al., 2021). Insufficient recovery can contribute to the onset of (a) overtraining syndrome, characterized by fatigue and performance decline (Meeusen et al., 2013), (b) burnout syndrome, characterized by exhaustion, reduced sense of accomplishment, and sport devaluation (Eklund & DeFreese, 2020), and (c) poor mental health (Caviedes et al., 2023).

However, gaps remain in our understanding of the relationship between rest and recovery. Although rest is proposed to contribute to recovery (i.e., as a recovery strategy), rest has not been studied as much as other recovery strategies such as massage (Kellmann, 2010). There has been little consideration about what rest means in mental (vs. physical) terms, how such mental rest might contribute to recovery, and how it might be obtained. The traditional conceptualization of rest (i.e., cessation of physical engagement in one's sport) might be insufficient in

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accounting for the experience of mental rest. For example, our interpretation of the quote by Jared Goff above is that mental rest involves the cessation of thinking about one's sport but the cessation of physical engagement in one's sport does not guarantee a cessation of such thinking. Anecdotal evidence suggests that athletes spend more time worrying about their sport on rest (i.e., no physical engagement) days because they have more time to do so (Eccles et al., 2022).

The literature review by Eccles et al. (2022) also indicates that rest is considered key to understanding movement skill learning. Studies of practice-to-rest ratios optimal for learning movement skills have revealed that practice sessions that are distributed, in that they are separated by rest periods ranging from seconds to days, generally lead to better learning than massed practice, which involves little or no rest between sessions (Shea et al., 2000). One explanation for the beneficial effect of distributed practice is that the rest periods provided allow for memory consolidation (Shea et al., 2000). Memory consolidation involves the neurobiological metamorphosis of memories from relatively unstable states into a more permanent form, a process that lasts hours to days. New repetitions of the criterion task during this process disrupt the consolidation of the memory of the original repetition of that task, resulting in an impoverished memory.

However, conceptualizations of rest within the study of distributed practice are typically limited to the cessation of the physical practice of the skill (Young et al., 2021). There have been few considerations of how the qualities of the rest periods provided by distributed practice affect such learning. Relevant insights might be gleaned from research on effects of post-practice rest on the learning of cognitive tasks such as word memorization (Craig et al., 2018). This research indicates that learning is enhanced when practice is followed immediately by a mentally "quiescent" rest period characterized by little mental situation than by an equal-length period involving mental stimulation; for example, that involves performing a visuospatial task. The leading explanation for this *quiescence effect* (Craig et al., 2018) is that mental stimulation disrupts memory consolidation. This disruption results in an impoverished memory structure, and thus the more mentally quiescent the rest period, the better the learning. Research is now needed to identify the extent to which the quiescence effect holds for movement skill learning (cf. Humiston & Wamsley, 2018) and to ascertain what other qualities of mental rest within distributed practice schedules enhance such learning.

These gaps in understanding about mental rest and its role in recovery and movement skill learning led Eccles and Kazmier (2019) to undertake a study to obtain an initial understanding of this topic. These researchers interviewed a women's field hockey squad at a UK university and used inductive analysis to generate a model of mental rest in athletes. This model is shown in Fig. 1 and hereon we term it the *Eccles-Kazmier model* for brevity. Within the model, a distinction is proposed between a *psychological state* that involves the extent to which an athlete feels mentally rested and a *psychological process* of resting mentally that, when engaged in effectively, enhances this state; that is, leads to the athlete feeling more mentally rested. The psychological state of feeling mentally rested has several characteristics. Mentally rested athletes feel fresh; poorly mentally rested athletes feel tired. Mentally (vs. poorly) rested athletes also value, appreciate, and enjoy their sport more, are more motivated to engage in their sport, and apply more effort to their sport.

The process of resting mentally within the Eccles-Kazmier model comprises both sleep and resting while awake, referred to *wakeful resting*. Wakeful resting is conceptualized as a reduction in, or "break from" psychological experiences associated with sport participation that are deleterious to feeling mentally rested and, for each such experience, an increase in a contrasting psychological experience that contributes to feeling mentally rested, which is termed a *resting experience*. We describe these experiences here.

The first resting experience, abbreviated to RE1 in the Eccles-Kazmier model, involves a break from thinking about one's sport. Athletes feel that they are always thinking about their sport during the

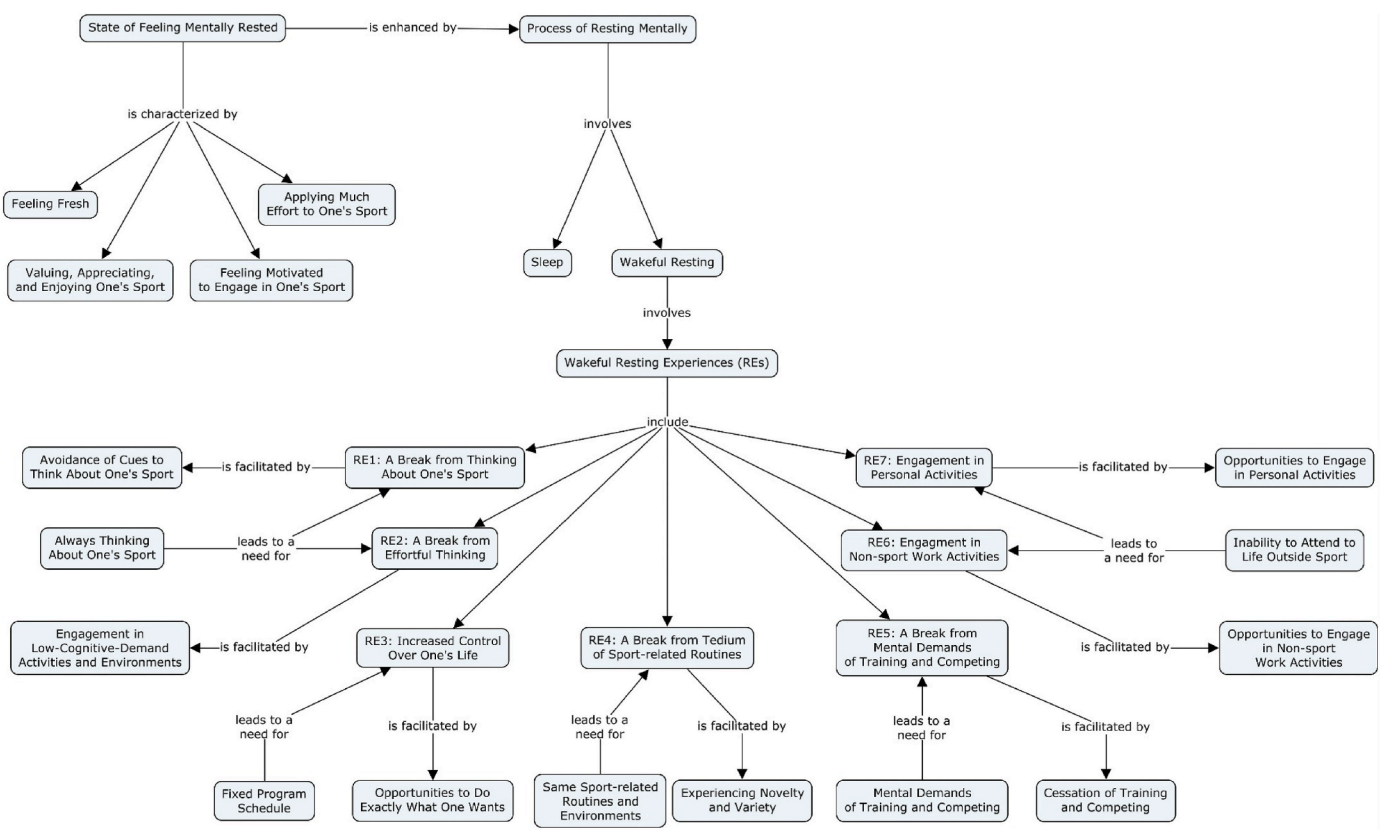

Fig. 1. The Eccles-Kazmier (2019) model of mental rest in athletes.

season because (a) they are constantly engaged in sport-related activities and (b) their sport is important to them. Always thinking about one's sport is deleterious to feeling well rested mentally. Such thinking elicits feelings of anxiety due to the association of this subject of thought with pressures to perform and, consequently, is mentally effortful and, over time, mentally fatiguing. Thus, a key resting experience involves a break from thinking about, or "switching off" from, one's sport when away from one's sport, such as on a rest day. The Eccles-Kazmier model also proposed that switching off is facilitated by avoiding cues to think about one's sport. Specifically, switching off on a rest day is facilitated by avoiding activities (e.g., reviewing game film), social environments (e.g., one's teammates), and physical environments (e.g., one's gym) related to one's sport. Also, because always thinking about one's sport is mentally fatiguing, athletes not only require a break from always thinking about one's sport but also from effortful thinking generally. Thus, the second resting experience in the model (RE2) involves a break from effortful thinking generally; that is, not just in relation to thinking about one's sport. This experience involves spending time during a rest day engaged in little effortful thinking, which is aided by engaging in activities and environments imposing few cognitive demands.

The third resting experience (RE3) involves perceptions of increased control over one's life. Athletes feel that their lives in the season are largely controlled by a fixed program schedule (e.g., training) and program directives on eating, sleeping, and socializing. External control is deleterious to feelings of being mentally rested because athletes want to have control over their lives and, consequently, feeling externally controlled by their program reduces their motivation to engage in the program. Consequently, a key resting experience involves assuming control over one's life, an experience that can be achieved by spending some time on a rest day doing exactly what one wants. The fourth resting experience (RE4) involves a break from the tedium of one's sport-related routines. Athletes spend much time following the same routines (e.g., training schedules) and in the same physical (e.g., training venues) and social (e.g., teammates) environments. These experiences of tedium are aversive and, over time, reduce athletes' motivation to engage in their sport programs. Thus, a key resting experience involves experiencing novelty and variety in routines and social and physical environments, an experience that can be achieved by spending time on a rest day doing an activity, in a location, and with people different from normal.

The fifth resting experience (RE5) involves a break from the mental demands of training and competing. Training and competition activities are mentally demanding and thus deleterious to feelings of being mentally rested. These activities require much concentration, which is cognitively demanding, and are also emotionally demanding given pressures to perform. Thus, a key resting experience involves a break from the mental demands of training and competing, which is obtained by getting a break from training and competing. The final two resting experiences proposed in the Eccles-Kazmier model are concerned with life outside sport. Due to sport commitments, athletes often feel unable to pay enough attention to life beyond their sport. Outside sport, athletes often must undertake work activities (e.g., for college athletes, studying) and feel stressed when unable to due to sport commitments. Athletes also want to engage in personal activities (e.g., relationships, hobbies) and they experience frustration when unable to due to sport commitments. The stress and frustration arising from these opportunity costs is deleterious to feeling mentally rested. Thus, key resting experiences include being able to spend some time on a rest day in (non-sport) work activities (RE6) and personal activities (RE7) because engaging in these activities results, respectively, in a reduction of stress associated with work-related opportunity costs and of frustration associated with personal opportunity costs.

As stated, we used the Eccles-Kazmier model to inform our study of mental rest in professional athletes. Our study constitutes an initial examination of the extent to which the model, which is based on college athletes, offers analytical generalizability to other athlete populations (Eccles et al., 2023; Smith, 2018). Our rationale for studying the professional athlete population in particular is that there is a need to better understand mental rest in this population. There is a trend across professional sports of increases in the number of games athletes are asked to play per season and thus in the psychological demands on professional athletes to perform (Florio, 2024, para. 1; Gouttebarge et al., 2019; Spiers, 2023, para. 5). This trend provides professional athletes with fewer opportunities for mental rest, which is likely to negatively affect recovery and movement skill learning and in turn athlete performance and health (Eccles et al., 2022). Our rationale for studying NFL athletes in particular is that little research attention has been paid to understanding mental rest in football and, moreover, to psychological aspects of this sport in general (cf. McGraw et al., 2018, 2019). Understanding gained from studying NFL athletes might also apply to other professional sports that are highly selective (i.e., few meet the required performance standard), highly paid, and involve much visibility in the public domain, such as basketball, golf, soccer, and tennis (Law, 2019; Roderick, 2006).

We were curious about the potential analytical generalizability of the Eccles-Kazmier model to professional athletes, and NFL athletes in particular, given the different demands faced by college and professional athletes, which we briefly mentioned above. College athletes are considered dual-career athletes due to their need to balance sport with academics (Linnér et al., 2022). By contrast, professional athletes are single career athletes able to focus solely on their sport. However, unlike for college athletes, for professional athletes, their sport is also their job, which often provides their only means of income, and their employment is precarious and short (Culvin, 2023; Roderick, 2006); the average NFL career length is 5.5 years (Baker et al., 2019). These differences in the demands of college and professional sport might limit the analytical generalizability of the Eccles-Kazmier model to the professional athlete context. In addition, our sample of NFL athletes differed from Eccles and Kazmier's sample on other demographic dimensions, beyond competitive level. Eccles and Kazmier's sample was white, mostly female, and resided in the UK, whereas, as described below, our sample was mostly African-American, male, and resided in the USA. These demographic differences might play a role in how mental rest is understood by athletes and thus limit the analytical generalizability of the model from the Eccles and Kazmier sample to our own.

1. Method

1.1. Participants

Participants were 16 male football players from eight different NFL franchises. Participants were under contract with their franchise at the time of the study. They were African American ($n = 13$) or White ($n = 3$), their mean age in years was 26.50 ($SD = 3.43$), and their mean number of seasons playing in the league was 4.69 ($SD = 3.20$).

1.2. Research philosophy and design

The research philosophy we adopted was primarily constructivist but also featured post-positivist elements (cf. Hill & Knox, 2021). We believe that reality is multiple, created, and mind-dependent, and that knowledge is co-constructed and subjective, consistent with a constructivist view. Thus, we employed methods, such as semi-structured interviews comprising open-ended questions, that enabled us to co-construct, with professional athletes, an understanding of these athletes' lived experiences of mental rest. However, more aligned with a post-positivist research approach, we wished to identify commonalities of experiences across participants, with the aim of identifying summary findings that could be compared with the (summary) concepts proposed within the Eccles-Kazmier model.

We used a qualitative description research design (Sandelowski, 2000). This design is useful for providing answers to research questions of practical relevance (Sandelowski, 2000) and our research question

was inherently practical: Given that rest is important to recovery and movement skill learning in sport, we aimed to identify what mental aspects of rest mean to professional athletes and how they get mental rest. Also, qualitative description provides relatively straight answers to research questions (Sandelowski, 2000), which was useful because we had no need to transform our data according to a particular interpretative paradigm such as phenomenology.

2. Interview method

We used an interview method because it affords conversations, which are a vital source of rich and new knowledge, and offers flexibility, allowing for exploration of avenues of knowing not previously considered (Smith & Sparkes, 2016). We employed a semi-structured interview guide because we wanted to ask participants questions that were focused on a specific topic but also open-ended in nature, affording flexibility to uncover unknown aspects of this little-researched area (Smith & Sparkes, 2016). Given our objective of understanding mental rest in professional athletes, the interview guide contained questions about what mental rest means to the professional athletes and their experiences of mental rest in their work. We perceived that the term "mental rest" might not be easily understood by participants and therefore our interview questions asked about "rest"; during the analysis, we identified responses pertaining to mental aspects of rest, as described below. As such, the first question was, what does rest mean to you as a professional athlete? As this example question evidences, the guide questions were as open as possible with the aim of exploring new avenues of knowing. Specific open-ended questions followed that were aimed at eliciting more details about meanings and experiences of mental rest. For example, to understand what constitutes effective and ineffective mental rest, participants were asked: "Can you recall any experiences where you feel you were able/unable to achieve effective rest during the season?" Where appropriate, we unpacked responses to questions using detail-oriented and elaboration explorations (Smith & Sparkes, 2016).

2.1. Procedure

Ethical approval was obtained from the host institution. A convenience sampling strategy was used to obtain participants. The study was conducted by three researchers, hereon *Researchers A, B,* and *C*. Potential participants were identified via personal contacts of Researcher A. In addition, Researcher B was a clinical psychologist employed by an NFL franchise, which had agreed to the study being undertaken. During two of her regular meetings with all 70 players on the team roster, Researcher B discussed the nature of the study, her involvement in it, and how she was looking for volunteers to participate. To mitigate player perceptions of pressures to participate, Researcher B made clear that participation was voluntary and unrelated to her normal work within the franchise, and that player decisions about participation were unrelated to, and could not affect their work for the franchise. She then invited players to inform her at any time after the meeting if they wanted to participate. Of the 70 players, five volunteered to participate.

When a player expressed interest in volunteering, the researcher arranged an interview either by telephone with Researcher A ($n = 11$) or in person at the training facility with Researcher B ($n = 5$). Informed consent was sought at the beginning of the interview. Interviews were recorded. The shortest interview duration was 13 min and the longest was 45 min ($M = 24.50$, $SD = 10.89$). We appreciate that the interviews were relatively short. The reason for this is that NFL players are a hard-to-reach population (Ellard-Gray et al., 2015), akin to other highly paid and publicly visible professional athletes such as soccer players (Law, 2019). NFL players are hard to reach because they are few in number, are mistrustful of outsiders at both the organizational and individual player level, and have busy schedules, especially during the season (cf. Law, 2019). Qualitative researchers (e.g., Vindrola-Padros et al., 2020) using interview methods have proposed that one strategy for accessing hard-to-reach populations is to employ brief interviews (e.g., 15 min) and schedule interviews when most convenient for participants such as during lunch breaks. Thus, to enhance recruitment, Researcher B suggested to players interested in participating that they meet during one of their workday breaks and in a room within the training facility. Because breaks in an NFL workday are short, the duration of the interviews was also relatively short, and included the shortest interview, described above.

2.2. Analysis

A thematic analysis of data was undertaken. The analysis was conducted by Researcher A only (excepting a critical friend, described below) because Researchers B and C were occupied with other work and thus were unable to devote the attention required for the analysis. The analysis involved a non-linear, multiple-step process. In step one, the interviews were transcribed verbatim, excepting removal of personal identifiers. Then, the researcher read each transcript to become immersed in the data and jotted down early reflections on the data such as "During the busyness of the season, using small spaces [of time to rest] is important". In step two, the researcher undertook an initial coding of the data.

Given the aim of exploring the analytical generalizability of the Eccles-Kazmier model, while also exploring unknown aspects of mental rest in professional athletes, a medium Q approach to thematic analysis was adopted (Braun & Clarke, 2022). Medium Q approaches to thematic analysis sit between "Big Q″ approaches and structured coding approaches (Braun & Clarke, 2022, p. 242). Big Q approaches are typified by fully inductive procedures that are used to generate codes from raw data in an open and organic way. Structured coding approaches are typified by deductive procedures that involve categorizing raw data, often exhaustively, according to codes developed in advance of the research study based on extant theory. Thus, medium Q approaches involve some blend of these two approaches.

The deductive procedures adopted within our Medium Q approach were as follows. A coding frame (hereon, *codebook*; Braun & Clarke, 2022) was created in advance of the study based on the Eccles-Kazmier model and comprised codes representing "anticipated themes" (Braun & Clarke, 2022, p. 243). The researcher anticipated from the model that he would identify a distinction between the extent to which players feel mentally rested (i.e., a psychological state) and a process of resting mentally, which led him to include two codes in the codebook: *state of feeling mentally rested* and *mental resting process*. Within the resting process code, the researcher included eight sub-codes. These codes represented sleep and the seven wakeful resting experiences that constituted the mental resting process within the Eccles-Kazmier model (i.e., RE1 through RE7); the code labels were *sleep, stop thinking about football*, *break from effort*, *control*, *break from tedium*, *reduced sport [i.e., training and competing] demands*, *work opportunities*, and *personal opportunities*, respectively. During analysis, he tagged text segments identified as pertaining to these codes accordingly. For example, the text segment "Researcher: So how do those opportunities help you? Player: It gives me a little bolt of energy" with the "state of feeling mentally rested" code.

The inductive procedures adopted within our Medium Q approach were as follows. First, in addition to (deductively) tagging text segments identified as evidencing the resting experiences proposed in the Eccles-Kazmier model, as described above, the researcher also (inductively) sought evidence of previously undocumented mental resting experiences; that is, those not featuring in the model. Second, the researcher also wanted to richly describe the nature of the *a priori* themes used as the basis for the codebook codes. Therefore, when a given text segment was tagged with a codebook code, this segment was also coded in terms of the unique content of the segment. For example, once the researcher had tagged the text segment "It gives me a little bolt of energy" with the "state of feeling mentally rested" code, he then created a new code

labelled "increased energy" and attached a note to this code reading "being mentally rested involves having more energy." In step three, the researcher grouped together similar codes that he had inductively generated to develop preliminary subthemes. For example, two codes concerning the state of feeling mentally rested were having a clear mind and being free from distractions. The researcher grouped these codes together because they were each concerned with attention and/or cognition. Subsequently, reading and reflecting on these codes and the identification of additional similar codes, and on the text segments associated with these codes, led the researcher to develop a preliminary subtheme of the perceptual-cognitive characteristics of the state of feeling mentally rested.

In step four, the researcher reviewed the preliminary subthemes in relation to the raw text segments. He also revisited previous analytical steps because some codes and preliminary subthemes were underdeveloped or required reworking. In step five, preliminary subthemes were defined and labelled, which involved reviewing codes within the subthemes to identify the extent to which the definitions and labels aptly reflected the data. In step six, the researcher wrote up a report of the results of the study. Throughout the analysis, the researcher used methods to enhance openness to alternative data interpretations. He was reflexive about his interpretations, including in the light of his positionality (see below), and noted his reflections during analysis.

In addition, a critical friend was employed. This friend is a faculty member and qualitative researcher at a university different from Researcher A's university and is also contracted as a mental performance consultant within professional sport but not within professional football. At six junctures within data collection and analysis, the critical friend critiqued Researcher A's initial interpretations of raw data, written descriptions of results, and reconciliation of results with extant theory (Smith & McGannon, 2018). For example, the researcher had created a note tagged to the *personal opportunities* code stating that the off-season provided more opportunities than the season to engage in personal activities. The critical friend read the raw data coded with this code and remarked that these data seemed to indicate that, for a subset of personal activities (e.g., spending time with family members located a great distance away), the busyness of the season did not simply reduce engagement in those activities, as stated in the researcher's note, but prevented it entirely. Consequently, the researcher revisited these data and came to appreciate how they evidenced the concept identified by the critical friend, which in turn led him to revise his original note to reflect his refined understanding.

2.3. Positionality

The researchers were reflexive about how their identities related to the research topic and participants' identities. Researcher A was partly responsible for interviewing and wholly responsible for the analysis, excepting the critical friend. He is a white, male, sport psychology faculty member in his 50s from a large, public US university. He is familiar with research on topics related to the target topic of mental rest (e.g., burnout) and experienced in conducting interviews, including with athletes, albeit less so with professional athletes. He has participated throughout his life in a variety of outdoor sports, including trail running, at the recreational level. Researcher B was partly responsible for interviewing and provided reflections on the research report. She is a white, female, clinical psychologist in her 40s employed by an NFL franchise. She is familiar with research on topics related to the target topic of mental rest and interacts with professional football players in her daily work. She played basketball and indoor volleyball at the high school level in the US. Researcher C provided reflections on the research report and helped prepare it for publication. He is a white, male, sport psychology faculty member in his 30s from large, public US university. He is familiar with research on topics related to the target topic of mental rest and played football at the college level in the US.

The researchers' positionality undoubtedly shaped the co-constructions of knowledge. First, the researchers used the Eccles-Kazmier model to frame interpretations of the data. Second, Researcher A's more general familiarity with research within and beyond the field of sport psychology also shaped data interpretations. For example, this researcher's awareness of the research within sociology on celebrities, including those in sport, informed his interpretation of data concerning football players' public visibility (e.g., Roderick & Hockin-Boyers, 2024). Third, for some participants, Researcher B was an "insider" within professional football and her particular franchise. This likely facilitated establishing rapport. In contrast, as a university faculty member unfamiliar with professional football (beyond spectating), Researcher A was an "outsider," which might have made establishing rapport more challenging. However, his position might have prompted questions about professional football that were taken for granted by Researcher B during her interviews, given her familiarity with football. Finally, as white researchers from relatively privileged backgrounds, the researchers were undoubtedly limited in their ability to understand the experiences of African-American participants who reported being from relatively underprivileged backgrounds and particularly the pressures felt by those with family members depending on their incomes (Sue, 2017).

2.4. Research quality

We adopted several criteria to enhance the quality of our study: worthiness, meaningful coherence, sincerity, credibility, and rich rigor (Smith & McGannon, 2018). Examples of study features that relate to these criteria are as follows. Our research is worthy because mental rest is critical to recovery and skill learning in sport, as discussed above, yet there is limited extant research on this topic in professional athletes. An indicator of meaningful coherence includes use of a medium-Q analytical approach that allows for both deductive and inductive procedures that are used, respectively, to examine the analytical generalizability of extant theory and explore unknown aspects of mental rest in professional athletes. A marker of sincerity is our self-reflexivity, where an example is our considerations of positionality. Credibility is indicated by thick descriptions of rest-related themes that we attempt to show, and not just tell, in our results. Finally, rich rigor is reflected by inclusion of a sample of requisite variety, involving players at eight (from a total 32) NFL franchises, drawing on extant theory (i.e., the Eccles-Kazmier model), and explaining findings with reference to theories within and beyond sport psychology.

3. Results and discussion

Within this section, we present our findings and reconcile them with extant research and theory. Insight into the researchers' roles in co-constructing themes is provided by including their voices within some quotes (Smith & Sparkes, 2016), within which the researcher is abbreviated to "R" and participants to "P."

3.1. The state of feeling mentally rested

Players reported that the extent to which they feel mentally rested varies over time. They described various characteristics of feeling mentally rested, and feeling poorly mentally rested. In terms of perceptual-cognitive characteristics, players described being mentally rested as having a clear mind, which involves being free from distractions.

> R: Ok, can you tell me how you feel when you're feeling well rested?
>
> P: You have a clear mind. You come into the day with a clear mind. You're not worried about making the mistake you made the day before … because that's gonna show in your game play. Feeling rested, yeh … you've got a clear mind, you're focused, ready to ball.

In terms of energetic characteristics, players described being mentally rested as involving feelings of increased energy and freshness, especially on waking in the morning during the season. In contrast, one sign of being poorly mentally rested is "feeling foggy" on waking. In terms of motivational characteristics, being mentally rested involves feeling motivated about one's sport and feeling a "love of the game." In terms of sport enjoyment, mentally rested players feel happy, and enjoy training and competing.

Players also described various consequences of feeling mentally rested, and poorly mentally rested. In terms of sport performance, players are able to concentrate better and make fewer "mental errors" during practice and competition. Being mentally rested also affords better physical performance including being able to "run faster, jump higher." By contrast, players report that they "can't do the job as well" when they feel poorly mentally rested. Being poorly mentally rested also leads to poor health, which includes "getting sick" and "coughing more," and poor health behaviors, as described by P15.

> One of my first signs to know that like, all right, I'm not properly rested, typically I'm going to eat bad. I have the urge to eat bad.

Some of the characteristics and consequences of being mentally rested identified here appear consistent with those associated with effective movement skill learning. For example, players' reports of committing few mental errors are consistent with known outcomes of effective (versus poor) memory consolidation following movement skill practice (Shea et al., 2000). Also, some characteristics and consequences of being poorly mentally rested identified here appear consistent with those associated with insufficient recovery. For example, reports of poor health behaviors when poorly mentally rested are consistent with an *underrecovery trap*, whereby greater mental and physical fatigue, resulting from higher work demands, leads to less engagement in effective recovery processes (Balk et al., 2021).

3.2. The mental resting process

Players reported that the extent to which they feel mentally rested is enhanced via engagement in a process of resting mentally. Key modes of such resting include both sleep and resting while awake; hereon, *wakeful resting*. This finding is consistent with the Eccles-Kazmier model and is also reflected in the literature on mental fatigue. Within Kaplan's (1995) Attention Restoration Theory, sleep is "useful" but "insufficient" for reducing attention fatigue following attentionally demanding tasks, which also depends on wakeful resting.

3.3. Sleep

Players emphasized the importance of achieving a minimum amount of nighttime sleep (e.g., "at least 8 h") but also reported that, when possible, daytime napping was useful in supplementing amount of sleep obtained. This finding is in line with a review of research indicating that the most useful interventions aimed at enhancing sleep in athletes involve simply increasing the amount of nightly sleep obtained, known as *sleep extension* (Bonnar et al., 2018). Players in our study reported that they attempt to achieve this minimum amount of sleep by establishing and adhering to a sleep schedule involving a set bedtime, and employing strategies to help them adhere to such a schedule and fall asleep quickly. Examples included silencing phones, using white noise apps to block background noise, being mindful of the commute time to the training facility when identifying where to live to maximize time available for sleeping, and considering the choice and timing of activities on a rest day to avoid disruptions to scheduled bedtimes and to falling asleep. P8 provides evidence of this last strategy: "If your girlfriend wanna come over at 11pm and every day you're up at 6am, you need to tell them, hey you can come over at 8 and we can go to sleep at 11."

3.4. Wakeful resting

We identified evidence that six of the seven wakeful resting experiences outlined in the Eccles-Kazmier model are involved in the process of resting mentally in NFL players: A break from thinking about one's sport (RE1 in the model), a break from effortful thinking (RE2), increased control over one's life (RE3), a break from the tedium of sport-related routines (RE4), a break from the mental demands of training and competing (RE5), and engagement in personal activities (RE7). However, we found no evidence of the sixth resting experience outlined in the Eccles-Kazmier model (RE6), which involved spending time on a rest day catching up on non-sport work activities (e.g., academic study) outside of one's sport. We also found no evidence of previously undocumented mental resting experiences; that is, those not featuring in the model. We now describe the resting experiences for which we did find evidence and outline behavioral, social, and environmental conditions that help players obtain these experiences.

A Break from Thinking About One's Sport (RE1). As stated above, consistent with the Eccles-Kazmier model, a key wakeful resting experience involves obtaining a break from thinking about one's sport (RE1). Below, we describe how being an NFL player leads to a feeling that one is always thinking about one's sport, why obtaining a break from such thinking is restful mentally, and conditions that help players achieve such a break.

The Experience of Always Thinking About One's Sport. Being an NFL player often leads players to feel that they are "thinking about football all of the time." P4 describes here how this experience characterized his initial years in the NFL.

> The way I used to handle my business was I would spend all day at the facility and then I would come home and I would spend all my time at home worrying about what I was going to do the next day at the facility.

There are two key aspects of being an NFL player that lead players to feel that they are always thinking about football. First, there is a perception by players that they are *constantly engaged in football-related activities* during the season. Players feel they are "living in a world of football" during the season. Typically, Tuesday is the only weekly rest day provided to players, which means that Wednesday to Monday requires a "total focus" on football. This finding is consistent with the Eccles-Kazmier model, which proposes that a typical in-season week contains many sport-related activities, leading athletes to constantly think about their sport.

Second, players are always thinking about football due to the *importance of football* to them. Players are not only intrinsically interested in performing well in their sport but know that playing their sport is their job. They are also aware that their job is well-paying but is likely to last for only a few years and, during that time, requires that they perform well; as one player put it, "NFL means 'Not For Long'". Professional soccer players have also reported feelings of uncertainty about work, due to short contracts, a surplus of talented players, and vulnerability due to injury and aging (Culvin, 2023; Roderick, 2006). Also, many players in the present study reported that they were from underprivileged backgrounds and that family depended on their incomes, a finding reflected in prior studies of NFL players (McGraw et al., 2018, 2019). This combination of precarious employment and pressures to provide for family promotes constant thinking about football and especially one's performance. This reason why players are constantly thinking about their sport was not one proposed within the Eccles-Kazmier model, which is likely because college athletes, upon whom the model is based, do not earn a substantial income and thus do not experience pressures to support family.

Players reported that the experience of always thinking about football is deleterious to feeling mentally rested. Such thinking elicits feelings of anxiety due to the association of such thinking with pressures to perform, especially in the context of precarious employment. Consequently, always thinking about one's sport is mentally effortful and in

turn mentally fatiguing. Thus, a key resting experience (RE1) involves a break or "switching off" from thinking about football, as P1 proposes.

> I find myself thinking about it always and when I'm not even there, so when I am there at times I just won't feel as engaged. But if you get away from it and you don't really think about it and you get back in that setting, you're going to be alert, ready to catch everything, you're going to learn as much as you can, like you're going to be engaged and you're going to be happy to be there.

This resting experience is not only consistent with the Eccles-Kazmier model (i.e., with RE1) but aligns with research on professional soccer. In a case study by Roderick and Schumacker (2017), a professional soccer player reported that he was always thinking about his performance, which he described as "like ivy that grows in everything" (p. 169), and wanted to be able to "switch off" (p. 171) from such thinking when he was not training or competing.

Conditions That Help Players Obtain a Break from Always Thinking About Their Sport. Players reported that obtaining a break from thinking about football is aided by engaging in activities different from football. Engaging in a non-football activity helps shift one's focus away from football and to the alternative activity. This shift of focus is made easier when the non-football activity is of intrinsic interest because attention on the activity is easily sustained, making a switch back to thinking about football less likely. Players reported many activities with these characteristics, ranging from meditation to walking the dog. P6 proposed that players need to "find something other than football that you desire to do" to help them switch off outside of work and P3's advice for switching off was to "go on a walk, going out to eat, go see a movie." This finding is consistent with the Eccles-Kazmier model and also with research in occupational psychology indicating that switching off after work is aided by focusing on a non-work subject, which is facilitated by engaging in non-work activities (Sonnentag & Fritz, 2015).

The players in the current study also reported that switching-off is facilitated by avoiding cues serving as reminders of football. These cues include physical environments such as the training facility, stadium, and medical facilities, as illustrated by P7.

> R: What advice do you have for rookies so that they can "not make it all about ball all the time" [a phrase used by the player earlier in the interview]?

> P: Don't live in a building where you can see the stadium from your window. In my rookie year in training camp, which is just a six-week grind of breathing in football, for six weeks straight I stayed in the [hotel] across from the stadium. In my window waking up at 5:30am, all I see is the lights of the stadium. And I go home and I strip the blinds and all I see is the lights of the stadium every night. Every day I wake up and see the stadium, where you spend all your time, so you start to feel trapped. So, I vowed ever since then to live far enough where I feel like I'm outside of that bubble.

Cues to think about football also include specific social environments. For example, one player proposed that he avoids dating partners connected to football, which reduces the chances of conversations concerning football outside of work. Players also expressed how they often avoid social environments, such as restaurants, wherein they might be recognized by the public, so that they can avoid conversations about football, which are sometimes abusive.

There were times at [previous NFL franchise] I got recognized, and it became very annoying. I couldn't eat in peace, go out and shop, sight see, just enjoy my time. Everyone would want to talk about football, football, football, what I thought about this, what I thought about that. That was the last thing I wanted to talk about. I would much rather talk about something in the news or how the weather was, [but] it was always about football. It became tough at times. P15.

Concern over public recognition and unwanted conversations about football on rest days often leads players to choose to socialize with family or teammates in private settings such as at home. Such get-togethers also often involve activities unrelated to football (e.g., video games) and agreement on "no ball talk" during this time. Thus, compared to spending time in public, which risks unwanted conversations about football, spending time at home with family or teammates on a rest day often involves fewer conversations about football and thus more opportunities to switch off from thinking about football. When players do venture into the public domain, they sometimes adopt strategies to avoid conversations about their sport such as wearing clothing that hides their physique and face, and, if approached by the public, denying playing football and claiming they "work construction."

This finding diverges from the Eccles-Kazmier model. The college athletes studied by Eccles and Kazmier (2019) reported that they could not avoid sport-related people on a rest day by spending time at home because they roomed with teammates and also could not avoid sport-related people by going to their training facility. Consequently, to help them switch off, they often spent time on a rest day in a *third location* (i.e., neither home nor work; Oldenburg, 1989) containing few sport-related people, such as a coffee shop. By contrast, in the present study, recognizable players are often approached in third locations by the public, who want to talk about football. Consequently, they often stay home to avoid these social cues to think about football. These findings accord with research by Roderick and Hockin-Boyers (2024), who proposed that recognizable professional athletes can develop a *sportive agoraphobia.* This condition involves a fear of public spaces due to the threat of uninvited attention from strangers, which is anxiety provoking and emotionally fatiguing, and a coping strategy of constant caution about one's vulnerability to personal intrusion.

A Break from Effortful Thinking (RE2). Because constantly thinking about football is mentally fatiguing, players not only require a break from thinking specifically about football but also from effortful thinking generally (RE2). Achieving this break is facilitated by engaging in activities and environments involving low cognitive demands and avoiding those involving high cognitive demands. For example, P11 reported that "laying in bed, sitting on the couch with my wife watching TV, that's kinda what I think of as resting" and P6 reported that mentally resting after work involved "watching simple stuff [on TV], Full House, Friends, HGTV." In addition, most activities reported by players as helping them get a break from thinking about football (i.e., RE1, described above) also impose only a relatively low cognitive demand, allowing a break from effortful thinking. Spending time alone or with close family and friends and in a quiet location also provides players with a low cognitive demand environment. Players also reported how they typically "take a break" after coming home from work by engaging in a low-demand activity, alone or with close family or friends, and in a quiet location, as P2 explains.

> Once our day is over, you come home and sit down and relax for a few hours. You definitely have some time to just sit down and kind of unwind. Sometimes I take a quick nap, watch some TV, talk on the phone to my loved ones. Nothing too crazy, just kind of sit down and not do anything for a little bit.

This finding is not only consistent with the Eccles-Kazmier model but also with the findings of a large public survey of rest by Hammond and Lewis (2016), in which undemanding activities such as listening to music were highly rated in terms of being restful.

Increased Control over One's Life (RE3). Players feel that their lives during the season are controlled by a relatively fixed work schedule. External control is deleterious to feeling mentally rested because players want some time when they can experience control over their lives, which they express as "me time" or "my time". Consequently, external control within their work environment reduces motivation to engage in their sport. Thus, a key resting experience (RE3) involves assuming more control over one's life, as described by P12.

> Rest is feeling like I've broken apart my day and given me more control of it, especially with the NFL schedule that mandates wherever you go and wherever things are done, it's hard to feel like you have

control. Even if I have 10 min where no one can tell me what to do, it helps me get more control of my day than just doing what they want me to do again. It's the ability to set my schedule and say "I need to do what I want right now; " it's having my own time and my own space.

This finding is not only consistent with the Eccles-Kazmier model but also reflected within self-determination theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000). Within this theory, assuming control is an inherently rewarding psychological experience, satisfying a basic psychological need for autonomy.

A Break from the Tedium of Sport-Related Routines (RE4). As the season progresses, players feel their lives become tedious and lack variety, which is deleterious to feeling mentally rested. Players reported spending much time during the season following the same routines, and within the same physical and social environments, as P11 describes: "in the [same] building every single day with the same people, with the same objective." Experiences of tedium are aversive and reduce players' motivation for their work. Thus, a key resting experience (RE4) involves a break from the tedium of sport-related routines and environments and, in contrast, experiencing novelty and variety in one's routines and environments, as described by P6.

> There's a three-to-four day break; they'll [i.e., coaches] recommend you go somewhere, they're like "just get away." You definitely have to get away, definitely don't wanna be stuck in [US city] doing the same ol', same ol' work and whatnot that you do at home.

This finding is not only consistent with the Eccles-Kazmier model but also with proposals that elite athletes' daily training is characterized by "sustained mundanity" (Baker, 2022, p. 154). The finding also accords with proposals that novelty, defined as something that "deviates from everyday routine," is a basic psychological need inherent to self-determined motivation (González-Cutre et al., 2016). From this perspective, resting mentally involves satisfying the professional athlete's need for novelty by experiencing routines and environments different from those associated with their sport.

A Break from the Mental Demands of Training and Competing (RE5). Players find that training and competing are mentally demanding because they require much concentration, as P16 proposes: "Game planning and then in-game, it's a huge mental load." Experiences of these demands are deleterious to feeling mentally rested and thus a key resting experience (RE5) involves a break from these mental demands, which is facilitated by a break in training and games. This finding accords with the Eccles-Kazmier model, within which college athletes reported that resting mentally involves a break from the mental load imposed by training and competition. The finding also aligns with research on professional soccer indicating that post-match (versus pre-match) mental fatigue is significantly elevated, presumably due to mental demands imposed by match play (Thompson et al., 2020).

Engagement in Personal Activities (RE7). Players often feel unable to engage in personal activities outside their sport during the season due to limited free time. First, players are not able to spend as much time as they would like on interests and hobbies outside of football, as P13 explains; note that the 18-week NFL season contains one *bye week* during which no game is scheduled, allowing players several rest days.

> Having these days off [during the bye week] allows you to step back into reality. You go to the grocery store, hop on the BBQ grill, swim, different things you don't do during the season, play golf. It's always nice.

Second, players are not able to spend as much time as they would like with family and friends, as evidenced by P2.

> R: If I could ask you about your last break between the seasons, what did you get up to?
>
> P: A lot of travelling, to see friends and family that you don't get to do during the season because our schedules are so tough. I was spending time with loved ones, family members and getting to go to see them as opposed to them coming to see you.

Feeling unable to engage in personal activities outside sport during the season leads to experiences of frustration, which are deleterious to feeling mentally rested. Thus, a key resting experience (RE7) includes a reduction of this frustration, which is obtained by being able to re-engage in personal activities outside sport. This finding is not only consistent with the Eccles-Kazmier model but also with the concept of *other priorities* (i.e., those outside sport) theorized to affect sport commitment (Scanlan et al., 2003). According to Scanlan et al. (2003), not being able to attend to priorities outside of sport due to sporting obligations leads to a sense of lost opportunities and in turn negative affect, which, over time, undermines sport commitment.

3.5. Opportunities to engage in the mental resting process in the season and off-season

Opportunities to engage in mental resting (i.e., obtain sleep and wakeful resting experiences) differ between the season and off-season. These differences are described below.

Resting Mentally in the Season. The best opportunity for resting mentally in a typical week in the season is the Tuesday rest day, which involves no scheduled training or games. On this day, players report attempts to "catch up" on sleep by sleeping later in the morning and napping during the day. If they need to attend their facility (e.g., for injury rehabilitation) or undertake errands, they tend to confine these activities to the morning. For the remainder of the day, they attempt to spend more time than normal engaged in activities that afford wakeful resting experiences. In the evening, players must often do some work (e.g., study game film) and must prepare for the following day. Bedtime is around 10pm for a 6am start for work the next day, and the typical workday concludes anytime from late afternoon. P1 describes attempts on the Tuesday rest day to obtain more sleep and various wakeful resting experiences, including a break from thinking about football (RE1) and from effortful thinking more generally (RE2).

> Tuesday is our universal off day. I usually sleep in, as from waking up early, so I'll wake up around 9am. Then I get up, go to the facility, watch a little film, work out. If I have anything to do, some running around, I get that done and then after that I go back [home]. I get a massage [in my home], which relaxes me a lot, and likely I just catch a good movie that I haven't seen. And just relax and not really think about ball [i.e., football]. Right before bed I look back over my game plan and watch a little bit more film.

The bye week provides another opportunity to obtain wakeful resting experiences. Compared to the Tuesday rest day, the additional time off during the bye week provides more opportunities to engage in the mental resting process. Players often travel away from the city they play in, allowing them to escape the various forms of cue that serve as reminders of their work (described above), which facilitates attempts to stop thinking about football (RE1). They also have better opportunities to engage in personal activities (RE7), which includes visiting family who are seldom seen because they live long distances away, as P6 explains.

> The bye week is incredible because we get that week off pretty much. So, I'm able to combine a lot of the things I love during the bye week. I travel, usually back home or to New York; there's no other place [like New York] to be able to kind of escape everything mentally. I'm also able to just spend family time and eat good.

Despite these opportunities for resting mentally, players feel that they do not have enough time for such resting during the season. Consequently, they often do not feel adequately mentally rested and especially as the season progresses. These experiences are captured here by P9.

> During the season, you get to a point where like, ok, if sh*t wasn't on the line, this wasn't my job, I'd sit down for two days. I'd sit down for

> two, three days, then I'll get right back to it. Like, if we got out of practice and we added 8 more hours to the day, and we were able to sit still for 8 hours [I'd feel adequately rested].

The limited free time during a typical in-season week also means that players must be strategic about engaging in the mental resting process. For example, P7 reported that he spends time doing hobbies during the season because it helps him stop thinking about football (RE1) but must be considerate of how to integrate them into his busy weekly schedule.

> It [a hobby] can be done, it just has to be alongside or attached to things you would be doing anyways. So, you're not going to go and join a chess or a book club, but things you can do inside your home, maybe is read a book. Because trying to add additional things doesn't work, you have to find the kind of easiest integration points for those hobbies.

The finding that players feel that they are not able to engage enough in the mental resting process during the season, such that increasingly they feel poorly mentally rested, is consistent with studies indicating that player performance and health suffers without sufficient rest between games (Gouttebarge et al., 2019). Furthermore, the trend across professional sports of increases in games played per season has led to calls from athletes (Florio, 2024, para. 1), coaches (Spiers, 2023, para. 5), and player unions (Gouttebarge et al., 2019) for more scheduled in-season rest days to reduce athlete burnout and injury.

Resting Mentally in the Off-Season. Compared to the season, the off-season provides many opportunities to engage in the mental resting process. The off-season involves a 10-week break from the demands of scheduled training and games (RE5). This break means players assume much greater control over their daily lives (RE3). Greater control allows players to sleep more and when they want. It also allows them to engage in more personal activities, especially those they feel have been "on hold" during the season (RE7). Their choice of personal activity is no longer constrained by the need to consider the "easiest integration points" (discussed above) of these activities into a busy in-season schedule. P5 explained that the off-season allows him to "make up for that lost time, the time you lost in the season." And for P10, the off-season means:

> Being able to see friends and family that you don't get to during the season because our schedules are so tough. Definitely spending time with loved ones, getting to go see them. It gives you a refresher just to spend time with them; it remotivates you without a doubt.

This increase in engagement in personal activities during the off-season also leads players to think less about football (RE1) because these activities are typically unrelated to football. Engaging in these activities also affords a break from the tedium of in-season routines and environments (RE4). For example, compared to in-season, travelling for vacations involves much variety in routines and environments.

Engagement in the mental resting process appears greatest in the first few weeks of the off-season to compensate for the few in-season opportunities for mental resting. By contrast, later weeks in the off-season are characterized by a re-engagement in thinking about football and an increase in physical and mental preparation for the beginning of the new season.

> Those first couple weeks are really big on laying around and just resting and being a couch potato. I usually do a little travelling, so I have a mixture of that to kind of get my mind away from ball. And enjoy the fruits of the labor. You worked hard the whole season, let's go and let me do this or let me do that; something that I love doing. P14.

These findings about the off-season can be reconciled with a conceptualization of off-season recovery in professional rugby proposed by Mellalieu et al. (2023). Similar to their framework, we identified that the off-season involves different phases, where the earlier phase(s) involves attempts to rest and last phase preparation for next season. However, the sole psychological mechanism underlying the recovery process in Mellalieu et al.'s framework is cognitive detachment from rugby (p. 6), which is akin to getting a break from thinking about football (RE1) in our study. As such, when Mellalieu et al.'s rugby players reported that an off-season recovery strategy included spending time with family, the (only) explanation for how this activity promoted recovery is that it facilitated cognitive detachment. In contrast, our study findings indicate that the mental resting process for football players involves multiple resting experiences, each with distinct psychological mechanism(s) that give rise to feeling more mentally rested. Thus, for football players, off-season family time does not only help them stop thinking about their sport (i.e., RE1, and Mellalieu et al.'s cognitive detachment mechanism). It also helps them achieve a break from the tedium of sport-related routines (RE4), thereby satisfying a psychological need for variety, and engage in life outside sport, thereby reducing frustration about not being able to do so in-season (RE7).

4. Summary

In summary, the Eccles-Kazmier model, which was based on college athletes, offers considerable analytical generalizability to the context of professional athletes (Smith, 2018). Many model components appear to generalize to the professional athlete context. This generalizability is notable given differences in the demographics of our sample and Eccles and Kazmier's (2019) sample (e.g., male and female, respectively). Notwithstanding, there are important limits to this generalizability. Some aspects of the process of resting mentally are different for professional athletes than for college athletes and these differences appear to be due to unique aspects of being a professional athlete. First, compared to college athletes, professional athletes experience additional pressures (i.e., income dependency alongside job precarity) that promote the deleterious psychological experience of always thinking about one's sport, which likely makes the resting experience of switching off from thinking about one's sport (RE1 in the Eccles-Kazmier model) more salient for this population. Second, switching off on rest days can be difficult for professional athletes because, unlike college athletes, professionals are often publicly recognizable and thus unable to spend time in public spaces without being asked by the public about their job. Third, we found no evidence that spending time on a rest day catching up on work, such as academic study, outside of one's sport (i.e., RE6 in the Eccles-Kazmier model) constituted a resting experience for professional athletes. The basis for this divergence seems to be that, while college athletes must balance their sport with their academic commitments (i.e., they are dual-career athletes), professional athletes typically do not undertake work outside their job (i.e., they are single-career athletes).

Our findings can be interpreted in relation to theory and research concerning recovery and movement skill learning. It is likely that the mental resting process described here, which gives rise to feeling more mentally rested, does so by promoting both recovery, which involves the replenishment of physical and mental resources (Kellman et al., 2018), and movement skill learning, which involves memory consolidation following movement skill practice (Shea et al., 2000). For example, within our study, players reported that always thinking about football during the season leads them to feel mentally fatigued, and thus poorly mentally rested. Within the recovery literature, this state of mental fatigue is conceptualized as having depleted mental resources (Kellman et al., 2018). However, when players were able to switch off from thinking about their sport on a rest day (i.e., RE1), they reported feeling more mentally rested. Thus, from a recovery perspective, switching off allows players to replenish depleted mental resources; that is, to recover. It is also possible that a single wakeful resting experience functions to enhance *both* recovery and movement skill learning. For example, players reported spending time after coming home from work in activities and environments that impose few mental demands, which allowed

them to experience a break from effortful thinking (RE2). From a recovery perspective, this experience appears to involve few demands on attentional resources and thus allows for the replenishment of attentional resources that were depleted due to the need to concentrate across the earlier workday, thereby enhancing recovery (Kellman et al., 2018). From a movement skill learning perspective, this same experience of a break from effortful thinking appears to be a "quiescent" one, involving minimal mental stimulation (Craig et al., 2018). As such, the experience involves minimal interference with the consolidation of memories formed earlier in the workday during a movement skill practice session, leading to enhanced movement skill learning (Shea et al., 2000).

Our study has limitations. Each participant was interviewed once, yet resting mentally was considered by professional athletes as a dynamic process. In future, longitudinal methods should be used to study these dynamic qualities. Also, richer insights into the activities and social and physical environments that help athletes engage in the mental resting process could be gained using other qualitative methods including diary and video methods. It is also likely that there are limitations to the knowledge generated here. Unique aspects of being a professional NFL athlete, including a substantial salary and public recognition, made the mental resting process different for these athletes than for the college athletes studied by Eccles and Kazmier (2019). Although these aspects are found in other professional athlete populations (e.g., golfers), many professional athlete populations receive lower salaries and are less recognizable (Roderick, 2006), and our findings might not extend to them.

Our study has applied implications. Sport psychology consultants (SPCs) can help professional athletes adopt strategies identified here as facilitating engagement in the mental resting process (cf. Eccles et al., 2021). SPCs can work with athletes to brainstorm resting activities they can engage in during the season that help them obtain multiple mental resting experiences. Consider an athlete who grew up enjoying salmon fishing with family on mountain rivers in Oregon but plays professional sport in urban Cincinnati, Ohio. Although this athlete is mostly unable to do this activity during the season, they could spend some time watching videos about their hobby during rest periods. This single activity might help them obtain multiple mental resting experiences: a break from thinking about their sport (RE1), from effortful thinking more generally (RE2), and from the tedium of sport-related routines (RE4), and engagement in personal activities outside sport (RE7). Having brainstormed these activities, SPCs can then help athletes to identify the easiest integration points for these activities within their in-season schedules. In addition, the athletes in the present study, and those in some prior studies of professional athletes, reported that it is challenging to switch off from thinking about their sport (RE1) during rest periods (e.g., Culvin, 2023). For athletes who are publicly recognizable, SPCs can aid these athletes' efforts at switching off by guiding them through an audit of third place locations containing few social cues to think about their sport, so that they can spend time in these locations during rest breaks. For example, rugby player Dan Carter (2015) reported deliberately vacationing in countries where he is relatively unknown.

We interviewed professional athletes to better understand mental rest in this population. We found that the Eccles-Kazmier (2019) model of mental rest, which was based on college athletes, offers considerable analytical generalizability to the context of professional athletes (Smith, 2018). However, we also identified important limits to this generalizability. Some aspects of the process of resting mentally appear different for professional athletes than for college athletes owing to unique aspects of the professional athlete context. We look forward to future research on this exciting facet of the psychology of sport.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

David W. Eccles: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Heather Twedell:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Brady S. DeCouto:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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